Waters Treaty—which had survived four wars—immediately after the Pahalgam attack. The waters of the Indus are vital for Pakistan's agricultural needs, especially for the politically powerful provinces of Punjab and Sindh—more than Kashmir, rivers are seen as Pakistan's jugular vein. Though the suspension does not immediately stem the flow of water, India's threat of reviewing the treaty puts tremendous psychological pressure on the Pakistani leadership.

The New Sindoor Lines

When it came to military options, Operation Sindoor was a demonstration of the decisive force with which India would strike. While giving the armed forces a free hand to mount the Indian response, Modi told the three service chiefs in a meeting, "*Wahaan pe goli chalegi, to yahaan se gola chalega* (If they fire bullets, we respond with mortar shells)." The clear brief was to up the ante each time and give a befitting response to the terrorists and their state sponsors.

OP SINDOOR SAW INDIA GOING FOR THE HEAD OF THE SNAKE BY ATTACKING THE HQs OF KEY TERROR GROUPS IN PAKISTAN RATHER THAN JUST THE FOOT SOLDIERS

In his fiery, tough-talking address to the nation, Modi defined these actions as the "new normal" in India's fight against terror. As a top official involved in decision-making elaborates, "We are now going for the head of the snake, not just the foot soldiers. We have also sent them a clear message that there is no place where you can hide and that no matter where you are in Pakistan, we will hit you." Operation Sindoor was a clear embodiment of India's new approach. On Day 1 itself, the Indian armed forces targeted key terror hideouts, hitting not just Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK) but Pakistan's very heartland—the province of Punjab—for the first time since the 1971 war. The headquarters of two key terror outfits—the Jaish-e-Mohammed in Bahawalpur and the Lashkar-e-Taiba in Muridke near Lahore—were struck with precision.

Another element of Modi's strategy included calling Pakistan's nuclear bluff. After the first round of strikes by the two countries, US Vice President J.D. Vance reached out to the Indian premier on May 9 to inform him that Pakistan was going to dramatically escalate the war. Given that the two countries were nuclear-armed, his concern was that events were moving rapidly up the escalation ladder towards an all-out

DIPLOMACY

HOW THE GUNS FELL SILENT

Wary of the prospects of a wider conflagration, the US took a lead role in helping India and Pakistan hit the pause button in their bitter exchange

Graphic by **NILANJAN DAS**
Text by **PRADIP R. SAGAR**



MAY 8

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio speaks to External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar, emphasises the need for "immediate de-escalation", expresses US support for direct dialogue between India and Pakistan



That same day, in an interview on an American news channel, US Vice President J.D. Vance says, "We can't control these countries.... What we can try is encourage these folks to de-escalate a little bit. But we're not going to get involved in the middle of war, that's fundamentally none of our business...."